

Learning Objective 1.2: I can define and calculate fundamental antenna properties — gain, directivity, effective aperture, beamwidth, and sidelobe level — apply the reciprocity principle linking an antenna’s transmit and receive behavior, and use the Friis transmission equation to predict received power in a link.

Show your work. A **Documentation** line at the end is required (write **None** if you did not collaborate).

1. **Wave equation sanity check.** The 1-D wave equation from a lossless transmission line is

$$\frac{\partial^2 v}{\partial z^2} = LC \frac{\partial^2 v}{\partial t^2}.$$

- (a) Show by direct substitution that $v(z, t) = f(z - ut)$ is a solution for any twice-differentiable f , and find u in terms of L and C .

- (b) For a coaxial cable with $L = 250$ nH/m and $C = 100$ pF/m, compute the propagation speed u and the velocity factor u/c .

$u =$

$u/c =$

- (c) In one sentence, explain what a “velocity factor of 0.66” (typical of RG-58 coax) means physically.

2. **Time and space frequencies.** A plane wave in free space is $\vec{E}(z, t) = \hat{x}E_0 \cos(\omega t - kz)$.

- (a) For a signal at $f = 2.40\text{GHz}$ (Wi-Fi channel 6), compute ω , λ , and k .

$$\omega =$$
$$\lambda =$$
$$k =$$

- (b) How far does the wave crest travel in **one nanosecond**? Express your answer in wavelengths.

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- (c) At a fixed point in space, how many full oscillations does the field complete in **one nanosecond**?

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- (d) Sketch (by hand) $\vec{E}$ vs. z at $t = 0$ over a range of two wavelengths, then $\vec{E}$ vs. t at $z = 0$ over a range of two periods. Label the axes.

3. **Directivity from beamwidths.** A ground-based tracking antenna has half-power beamwidths $\theta_1 = 2.5^\circ$ in azimuth and $\theta_2 = 1.8^\circ$ in elevation.

- (a) Estimate the directivity in dBi using the pencil-beam approximation $D \approx 41,253/(\theta_1^\circ \theta_2^\circ)$.

$D =$

- (b) The antenna is measured to have radiation efficiency 88% and impedance mismatch $|\Gamma| = 0.25$. What is the realized gain at boresight, in dBi?

$G_{\text{re}} =$

- (c) In one sentence, explain the difference between D , G , and G_{re} for this antenna.

4. Effective area.

- (a) A parabolic dish for a satellite ground terminal has $G = 47$ dBi at $f = 12$ GHz. Compute the effective area $A_e = G\lambda^2/(4\pi)$.

$A_e =$

- (b) The dish is physically 2.4m in diameter. What is its aperture efficiency $\eta_{\text{ap}} = A_e/A_{\text{phys}}$? Is that reasonable?

$\eta_{\text{ap}} =$

- (c) Keeping the same physical dish but re-illuminating it efficiently at $f = 30$ GHz (Ka-band), what gain (dBi) would you expect if η_{ap} is unchanged?

$G_{30} =$

5. **Reading a real pattern.** Find a published radiation-pattern plot for a real antenna — a manufacturer datasheet, application note, or journal figure with a dB-labeled axis — and hand in the annotated plot with your readings. *Cite the source; answers are antenna-dependent, so the solutions grade method, not a specific number.*

(a) Boresight direction (degrees off nose).

(b) Half-power beamwidth (HPBW).

(c) First-null beamwidth (FNBW), or state if no null is visible in range.

(d) Peak sidelobe level (SLL), in dB below the main lobe.

(e) Front-to-back ratio (F/B), in dB.

6. **Friis link with gain and effective area.** A UHF ground station at $f = 400\text{MHz}$ transmits $P_t = 20\text{W}$ into an antenna with $G_t = 8\text{ dBi}$. A cubesat at $r = 800\text{ km}$ carries a receive antenna with $G_r = 3\text{ dBi}$ and is on boresight for both antennas. Take $\lambda = c/f = 0.75\text{m}$.

(a) Compute the on-axis power density S_{inc} at the cubesat.

$$S_{\text{inc}} =$$

(b) Compute the cubesat receive antenna's effective area $A_{e,r}$.

$$A_{e,r} =$$

(c) Compute the received power $P_r = S_{\text{inc}}A_{e,r}$ and express the result in dBm.

$$P_r =$$

(d) Verify your answer by computing P_r directly from the Friis equation $P_r = P_t G_t G_r \left(\frac{\lambda}{4\pi r} \right)^2$.

Documentation: _____